

CHECKPOINT PLANNING

Financial Clarity for Life's In-Betweens

YOUR NEXT CHECKPOINT

The Early Retirement Checkpoint Guide

A simple guide to the decisions that don't wait until 65.

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How to Use This Guide

This guide is designed to support you as you consider or move into early retirement. It is a companion to The Checkpoint Strategy™ and offers a simple way to organize your thinking before you make decisions that are difficult to undo.

What this guide is:

- A tool to help you gain clarity on the decisions that are unique to retiring early
- A place to capture questions before a conversation with a planner
- A simple structure for the next 90 days

What this guide is not:

- A full financial plan
 - Tax or legal advice
 - A replacement for a Social Security timing analysis or pension election review specific to your situation
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Where You Are Today

Retiring earlier than the standard timeline, by choice or otherwise, brings a different kind of transition than a typical retirement.

- What prompted this timeline? (a choice, a layoff, a health consideration, a spouse's plans)
- Three words that describe how I feel about retiring on this timeline:
- What I most want to protect as I make this decision:

There is no need to have this fully resolved today. Naming it is the first step.

The Five Decisions That Don't Wait

1. Healthcare Before Medicare

If you're retiring before 65, you need a coverage plan for the gap. Compare COBRA, ACA marketplace plans, and a spouse's employer coverage, including real monthly costs, not just premiums.

Question to answer: How many years until I'm Medicare-eligible, and what will coverage cost me until then?

2. Social Security Timing

Claiming early (as soon as 62), at full retirement age, or later (up to 70) changes your monthly benefit substantially and permanently. Retiring early doesn't mean you have to claim early.

Question to answer: Have I run the numbers on claiming at 62 vs. full retirement age vs. 70, not just the monthly amount, but the break-even age?

3. Pension Elections

If a pension is part of your retirement, lump sum vs. annuity and survivor benefit elections are typically permanent once made.

Question to answer: Do I understand the tradeoffs of every election option available to me, and has anyone modeled them side by side?

4. Portfolio Longevity

An early retirement means your savings need to last longer than a standard 30-year retirement horizon. A withdrawal rate that works for someone retiring at 65 may not work for someone retiring at 55.

Question to answer: Has anyone run a retirement readiness projection based on my actual retirement age, not a generic assumption?

5. Required Minimum Distributions (RMDs) and Roth Conversions

The years between early retirement and RMD age are often the best window for Roth conversions, when income, and tax rates, may be lower.

Question to answer: Am I using the low-income years before RMDs begin to my advantage?

Income Snapshot

List every income source that may apply once you retire.

Income Source	Current Monthly	Projected Monthly (Post-Retirement)
Pension		
Social Security (if claiming)		
Part-time work / consulting		
Portfolio withdrawals		
Spouse's income		
Other		
Total Monthly Income		

My First 90 Days Checkpoint

First 30 days, Stabilize

- Confirm health coverage start date and cost
- Understand any pension election deadlines

- Delay any irreversible decisions (Social Security claim, pension election, large withdrawals)

Next 30 days, Clarify

- Run a retirement income projection based on your real numbers
- Identify one professional to talk to (financial planner, tax advisor)

Final 30 days, Decide

- Make Social Security and pension elections with full information
 - Set your withdrawal strategy for year one
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Decisions I Do Not Need to Make Yet

Not every decision needs to happen before you retire. Write down what can wait, and when you'll revisit it.

- Decisions I can delay:
 - Earliest date these decisions need to be reviewed:
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Questions to Bring to a Professional

- Questions about Social Security timing:
 - Questions about pension elections:
 - Questions about portfolio withdrawal strategy:
 - Questions about healthcare coverage:
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If You Would Like Additional Support

This guide is designed to help you gain clarity as you consider early retirement. If you'd benefit from a deeper conversation about your specific numbers, support is available.

Schedule a complimentary Where We Begin session. It is not a financial plan and there is no obligation of any kind, a structured, confidential space to review where you are, what's changed, what decisions matter now, and what can wait.

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